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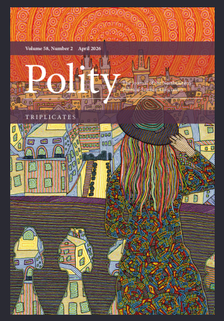

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ARTICLE

Nietzsche on the Origin & Development of the Distinctively Human

View article page

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Abstract

Professor Zuckert suggests that the main thrust of

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fundamentally different from that in Hegel's *The Phenomenology of the Spirit*. The master does not conquer and enslave from a desire for recognition, according to Nietzsche, and surely not for recognition from slaves. A desire for recognition presupposes an awareness of the importance of others and their opinions and a degree of self-doubt, a degree of rationality and self-reflection, that cannot be attributed to the unself-conscious, natural man. If man's potential reason is completely undeveloped, he cannot be characterized by either intentional action or desire, which is aroused, characterized, and defined by its object; the human animal must first be moved by some internal, but fundamentally irrational, impulse which leads him to develop his reason. And he will not turn back on and discover himself or use his reason until he encounters a force stronger than himself; the slave, by definition, does not represent such a force.

Hegel describes the master-slave relation as a stage in the process of man's coming to self-consciousness. In order to know or experience himself, his essential unity as opposed to the stream of transient impressions and desires of his sentient or simply animal existence, man has to risk his life to show that he himself is not the same as any or even the sum of these passing sensations. If he succeeds in severing himself from animal existence, if he dies, he will clearly lose his self-conscious along with his animal existence. To establish his own existence as something different from the mere animal desire for preservation or sensation, Hegel argues, man must acquire external recognition of himself. He tries, therefore, to conquer. By making another a slave, the master establishes his superiority in two respects. First, he commands and continues the mere attachment to animal existence represented by the slave, who always has the option of dying rather than serving. Second, the master commands the world or things by having the slave prepare them for consumption according to the master's desires. Although the slave appears inferior and dependent, Hegel continues, it is, in fact, the master who is fundamentally so, because the master depends upon the slave for

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